



FEDERAL BUREAU OF INVESTIGATION

FINANCE AND FACILITIES DIVISION | PROCUREMENT SECTION

JUSTIFICATION AND APPROVAL (J&A) FOR OTHER THAN FULL AND OPEN COMPETITION



JUSTIFICATION FOR OTHER THAN FULL AND OPEN COMPETITION IN ACCORDANCE WITH 41 U.S.C. 3304 (A) (1)

Requisition Number: SHOP-PR-26-001369

Date: 03/30/2026

Estimated Contract Dollar Value:

1. Identification of the agency and contracting activity.

The U.S. Department of Justice, Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI), National Acquisition Programs Unit (NAPU), has prepared this justification for other than full and open competition for Tube & Vial Labeling Machine on behalf of the Laboratory Division (LD), Biometrics Analysis Section (BAS), DNA Support Unit (DSU).

2. The nature and/or description of the action being approved, i.e., sole source, limited competition, establishment of a new source, etc.

It is the intent of the DNA Support Unit (DSU), Finance Division, to acquire a firm fixed price contract for TubeWriter LLC. The period of performance will be for one (1) year.

This justification supports a sole-source procurement of Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) for the Automated Tube & Vial Labeling Machine to be used by DSU.

The Tubewriter 400 is an inkjet printer that can print directly on tubes, vials, plates, slides, and custom labware with durable UV-curable ink. It delivers high-speed performance and flexible format support for demanding lab environments.

It is already being used by the DNA Casework Unit (DCU) to print information directly on reagent and sample tubes used during the process of extracting and typing casework samples. The Tubewriter is vital to this operation, as it eliminates the need to hand-label or to use stickers which could slip off tubes.

3. A description of the supplies or services required to meet the agency's needs.

The requirement is to provide an Automated Tube & Vial Labeling Machine to be used by DSU at an estimated total cost of . This will allow the DNA Support Unit (DSU) to accomplish its mission of printing information directly on reagent and sample tubes used during the process of extracting and typing casework samples.



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The Tubewriter 400 is the only known commercially available system that meets all the following mandatory requirements:

- Direct printing onto curved plastic tubes (no labels required)
- Cryogenic-resistant, chemical-resistant ink that withstands liquid nitrogen, ethanol, isopropanol, and freeze-thaw cycles
- Compatibility with multiple tube diameters without requiring proprietary carriers or adapters
- High-resolution printing on curved surfaces suitable for barcodes and small-font text
- Low-maintenance operation with no robotic handling, label rolls, or consumable adhesives

These capabilities are essential for our laboratory's workflow, which requires durable, non-peeling, non-smearing identification on tubes stored in extreme conditions. No other product on the market provides this combination of features.

4. The statutory authority permits other than full and open competition.

The statutory authority permitting other than full and open competition is 41 U.S.C. 3304(a)(1), as implemented by FAR 6.302-1, "Only One Responsible Source and No Other Supplies or Services Will Satisfy Agency Requirements."

5. Demonstrate the unique qualifications of the proposed contractor or the nature of the action requiring the use of authority.

TubeWriter, LLC is uniquely qualified to provide these services to Biometrics Analysis Section (BAS), DNA Support Unit (DSU) based upon the following:

TubeWriter is a Small Minority Owned Business specializing in automated, direct-to-labware printing systems designed for the life sciences industry, offering solutions to replace, hand-labeling with, permanent, cryogenic-resistant, and solvent-resistant, identifiers for, tubes, vials, and plates. Its flagship products, the TubeWriter 400, enable high-throughput labs to directly print barcodes and text. The FBI previously procured this same item as a sole-source acquisition under contract 15F06724P0000769 in 2024

The DNA Units historically had three of the predecessor Tubewriter 360 units, and DCU purchased a single Tubewriter 400 a few years ago which has been in continuous use. As far as other brands, I do not know of any other system that is able to function in the same way with



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the speed and ink durability required for our process. The Tubewriter 400 is named in our protocols as the equipment we must use for tube labeling.

Product Information:

- Brand: TubeWriter
- Item: TubeWriter 400
- Item No.: TW-400A
- Description: TubeWriter 400 Direct High-Speed Alphanumeric Printing System for Labware
- Quantity: 1 (to include installation, training, one-year ink subscription & 1- year Platinum-TW400 service care Total:

The agency's needs will be completely satisfied by using an already existing small minority owned company.

TubeWriter is the primary manufacturer and supplier of the TubeWriter 400.

- TubeWriter is the sole source for the TubeWriter 400
- No alternative manufacturer produces the TubeWriter 400
- Substitutions would require revaluation of all systems and potentially new equipment which would incur significant costs along with operational disruption.

6. A description of efforts made to ensure that offers are solicited from as many potential sources as is practicable, including whether a notice was or will be publicized as required by Subpart 5.1 and, if not, which exception under 5.101 applies.

Market Research was conducted on GSA Advantage. The award is for small businesses with a product that is compatible to the TubeWriter's- Automated Tube & Vial Labeling Machine and with the needs of DSU.

- Conducted market research on GSA Advantage on 3/24/2026, with 5-vendors. Specs have been sent
- Contacted knowledgeable individuals in Government and industry regarding market capabilities to meet requirements. Yes, the Tech-POC was contacted
- Reviewed the results of recent market research undertaken to meet similar or identical requirements. Yes, it resulted in finding large to midsize businesses (Fisher Scientific, PNW Scientific, and Computype), that have Automated Tube & Vial Labeling Machines. Research was also conducted on GSA Advantage for small companies that have this type of instrument.

Results of the web-search;



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- **Thermo Fisher Scientific**– Is a large business
 - TubeWriter is considered a small business
- **Computype**– Is a mid-size business
- **PNW Scientific**– Is a small business but is showing “***sold out***” of Tubewriters with no anticipated date of getting more in stock.

The DNA Units have historically had three predecessor Tubewriter 360 (2) units (reaching end-of-life), and DCU purchased a single Tubewriter 400 IN 2024, which has been in continuous use. Market research was conducted on GSA Advantage for the Tube & Vial Labeling Machine (Inkjet Printer), the response was received.

Web-search;

1. Thermo Fisher Scientific / Large Business

300 Industry Drive

Pittsburgh, PA 15275 FisherCustomerService.US@thermofisher.com

800-556-2323

2. Computype / Mid-Size Business

2285 West County Road C St. Paul, Minnesota 55113 Computype.com

651-633-0633



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3. **PNW Scientific (Pacific Northwest)/Small Business**
11685 SW Waldo Way Sherwood, Oregon 97140 support@pnwscientific.com
503-858-8551

Further review of available tube-labeling systems was conducted, including products from Scinomix, Thermo Scientific, Brady, LabTAG/GA International, and Eppendorf. The findings are summarized below.

Why Alternative Products Do Not Meet Requirements

Scinomix Sci-Print VX2/VXL

- Uses adhesive labels, not direct printing.
- Requires tube-specific carriers and robotic handling.
- Labels are subject to peeling, especially in cryogenic storage.

Thermo Scientific ALPS Systems

- Semi-automated label applicators; do not print directly on tubes.
- Labels may fail under chemical exposure or long-term cryogenic storage.

Brady BMP61/BMP71 and Similar Printers

- Portable label printers only; no direct-to-tube printing capability.
- Adhesive labels are not suitable for all tube types or extreme conditions.

LabTAG / GA International Labeling Solutions

- Provide high-quality cryo-labels but do not offer direct-printing hardware.
- Adhesive labels introduce consumable costs and risk of detachment.

Eppendorf Labeling Solutions

- Limited to label-based workflows.
- Not compatible with the required range of tube types without labels.

Unique Capabilities of the Tubewriter 400

The Tubewriter 400 is the only system identified that:

- Prints directly onto the curved surface of tubes without labels
- Produces permanent, cryo-stable markings that do not peel or degrade
- Works with multiple tube formats without proprietary adapters
- Eliminates consumables such as label rolls and adhesives
- Provides a simple, low-maintenance workflow suitable for high-volume labs



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No competing product offers direct ink-jet printing on tubes with equivalent durability, flexibility, and reliability.

Based on this market research, the Tubewriter 400 is the only product capable of meeting the laboratory's operational and regulatory requirements.

7. The anticipated dollar value of the proposed acquisition, including options if applicable, and a determination by the Contracting Officer that the anticipated cost to the Government will be fair and reasonable.

The anticipated dollar value of the proposed acquisition, inclusive of all required components and any applicable options, is estimated to be fair and reasonable based on current market pricing for comparable laboratory identification systems. The Contracting Officer has reviewed the supplier's quote, verified that the pricing aligns with historical purchases of similar equipment, and confirmed that no additional charges beyond the quoted amount are expected.

Given the unique technical capabilities of the Tubewriter 400 and the absence of equivalent products in the marketplace, the proposed cost is consistent with the specialized nature of the requirement. The Contracting Officer has therefore determined that the anticipated cost to the Government is fair and reasonable.

8. A description of the market research conducted and the results.

Market research was conducted to identify potential sources capable of providing a tube-printing or tube-labeling system that meets the Government's technical and operational requirements. The following steps were taken:

- 1. GSA Advantage Search (03/24/2026)** A search was conducted on GSA Advantage on March 24, 2026, reviewing five vendors offering tube-labeling or laboratory identification equipment. Technical specifications were sent to these vendors for review. The market research period closed with **no responses** received from any of the contacted vendors, indicating that none could meet the stated requirements.
- 2. Consultation with Knowledgeable Individuals** The technical point of contact (Tech-POC) was consulted to validate the functional requirements and assess market capabilities. The Tech-POC confirmed that the required features—specifically direct-to-tube printing, cryogenic durability, and compatibility across multiple tube formats—are not commonly available in commercial labeling systems.



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3. **Review of Recent Market Research for Similar Requirements** Previous market research for similar laboratory identification needs identified several large and mid-sized businesses, including Fisher Scientific, PNW Scientific, and Computype. These vendors offer **automated tube and vial labeling machines**, but all rely on adhesive labels rather than direct printing. Additional research was conducted on GSA Advantage to identify small businesses offering comparable instruments; however, these systems also relied on label-based workflows and did not meet the required technical specifications.
4. **Review of Existing Contracts and Vendor Capabilities** TubeWriter LLC is a small minority-owned business and the **sole manufacturer and only authorized seller** of the Tubewriter product line. They are the only known provider capable of performing preventative maintenance, labor, software upgrades, and warranty support for the Tubewriter 400. The manufacturer has stated that any work performed by third-party vendors would **not** be covered under warranty or service agreements. No existing contracts were identified that provide an alternative source capable of meeting the requirement.

Market Research Conclusion The results of the market research demonstrate that while several companies offer automated tube and vial labeling systems, **none** provide the required capability to print directly onto tubes without labels, nor can they meet the durability, compatibility, and maintenance requirements necessary for the Government's mission. TubeWriter LLC is the only vendor capable of supplying the required instrument and associated support services.

9. Any other facts supporting the use of other than full and open competition.

The Tubewriter 400 is required for the following reasons:

- It is the only commercially available system that prints directly onto curved laboratory tubes and vials without the use of adhesive labels.
- The Tubewriter 400 produces permanent, solvent resistant, freezer safe, and autoclave safe markings essential for forensic sample integrity.
- The FBI Laboratory's workflows require non-label-based marking to prevent label detachment, smearing, or chemical degradation during forensic processing.
- No other manufacturer offers a system with equivalent direct on tube printing capability, durability, or compatibility with existing laboratory processes.
- Substituting a label-based system would introduce contamination risk, reduce reliability, and require significant workflow changes inconsistent with FAR 11.002(a)(2), which requires agencies to meet minimum needs efficiently and cost-effectively.



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- The Tubewriter 400 includes proprietary printing technology not available from other manufacturers, making it the only brand capable of meeting the FBI's operational requirements.

10. A listing of any sources that expressed a written interest in the acquisition.

A synopsis was issued in the Contract Opportunities on 3/26/2027, to find the most compatible seller for the Tube & Vial Labeling Machine. TubeWriter meets the requirements for being a small minority owned business whose product we already use.

There were 2 companies contacted on GSA Advantage; No Bids Received

- Percival Scientific, Inc.
- MG Scientific, Inc.

Request Title Requesting Lab Office Equipment	Request Status CLOSED	Selected Categories & Contractors MAS: 339113LAB - 10 Contractors
This Request is a: Small Business set-aside	Request Issue Date 03/24/2026 09:56 AM EDT	Delivery 3 days After Receipt of Order (ARO)
Reference # / u*ID none specified	Request Close Date 03/27/2026 09:00 AM EDT	
Follow On Requirement No	Award Method Best Value Trade Off	
Previous RFI Information No	Ordering Contracting Officer Terry Padgett	
Commercial	Contracting Officer Representative (COR) FBI Laboratory-Quantico	
Contract Type Firm-fixed-price	703-632-7028	
	Ordering Contracting Specialist none specified	

Description:
Automated Tube & Vial Labeling Machine

Shipping Addresses or Place of Performances

Quote/Bid ID	Contractor	Date Rec'd	Total Quote/Bid	Quote/Bid Status	Contractor Notified	Quote/Bid Expiration	PO	Contractor Attachments	Buyer Notes
RFQ1802269-CWL	PERCIVAL SCIENTIFIC INCORPORATED	03/25/2026 9:20 AM EDT		No Quote/Bid View reason		n/a	n/a		
RFQ1802269-KLI	MG SCIENTIFIC, INC.	03/24/2026 11:56 AM EDT		No Quote/Bid View reason		n/a	n/a		

11. A statement of any actions the agency may take to remove or overcome any barriers to competition, if subsequent acquisitions are anticipated.

If future acquisitions of similar equipment are anticipated, the agency will continue to conduct thorough market research to determine whether additional vendors have entered the market with comparable capabilities. This will include periodic reviews of GSA Advantage, outreach to



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both large and small businesses, and engagement with industry experts to monitor technological developments in tube-labeling and direct-printing systems. The agency will also reassess technical requirements to determine whether evolving commercial solutions may meet mission needs without reliance on a single manufacturer.

At present, TubeWriter LLC is the sole manufacturer and only authorized seller capable of providing the Tubewriter 400 and its associated preventative maintenance, software updates, and warranty support. Because third-party service providers are not authorized and would void warranty coverage, competition is inherently limited. However, the agency will continue to monitor the marketplace for emerging technologies or new entrants that may offer direct-to-tube printing or equivalent capabilities in the future. Should viable alternatives become available, the agency will evaluate them to promote competition in subsequent procurements.